The Plateau

Situated within the Fraser and Columbia river basins, the Plateau region was surrounded by several other cultural areas. This area would be where the states of Washington, Oregon, Montana and Idaho are situated. The majority of people who lived in this region set up small villages along the riverbanks and other bodies of water. They lived off of fish, game animals, nuts and berries. In the south, the tribes of Yakama, Walla Walla, Modoc and the Klamath spoke dialects of the Penutian language. In the northern regions, the tribes spoke a dialect of the Salishan language. These tribes included the Spokane, Salish and the Skitswish.

Various Native American tribes introduced the horse into the Plateau region during the 18th century and horses quickly became an important part of the culture. The tribes here expanded their trading networks, improved the economy and became intermediaries between the Plains and Northwest tribes. Lewis and Clark, the famous explorers, arrived in the Plateau region in 1805. When they saw lush land to be taken, they called others to join them. By the end of the 1800s, the natives had been moved to reservations set up by the government.